B2 Reading

Understanding the writer's attitude

Spot the words that show what a writer really thinks, even when they never say "I think".

Writers often show their opinion through word choice rather than by stating it. Exam questions such as *What is the writer's attitude to...?* test whether you notice these signals.

Signal	Examples	What it shows
Evaluative adjectives	*a promising idea, a costly mistake*	Positive or negative judgement
Attitude adverbs	*surprisingly, unfortunately, admittedly*	The writer's reaction to a fact
Reporting verbs	*claims, insists, points out, admits*	Whether the writer trusts the source
Contrast words	*however, yet, even so*	Where the writer's real point usually comes

Text

The city council *claims* that the new bike lanes have reduced traffic. Admittedly, there are more cyclists on the main road than last year. Yet the council has published no figures, and the lanes stop suddenly at the busiest junctions, which is hardly a recipe for safety. It is a promising start, but it is far from the transport revolution we were promised.

Reporting verbs carry opinion. *Points out* means the writer agrees with the source. *Claims* often means the writer has doubts.

Common mistake. Choosing an answer because its words appear in the text. The text says *promising*, but the writer's overall attitude is critical: everything after *Yet* matters most.

Practice

1. Which word shows the writer doubts the council?
2. What does *Admittedly* tell you about the writer?
3. What is the effect of *hardly a recipe for safety*?
4. Overall, the writer's attitude to the bike lanes is: (a) enthusiastic (b) neutral (c) cautiously critical
5. Rewrite this neutral sentence to sound critical: *The report says sales went up.*

Teacher page: answers

Print the pages before this one for students.

Answers

1. *claims*
2. The writer accepts one point against their own view before arguing back.
3. It is understatement: the writer means the lanes are unsafe.
4. (c) cautiously critical
5. For example: *The report claims that sales went up.* | *The report insists, without evidence, that sales went up.*